

WATKINS PLUMBING · 30 YEARS IN CHICO

The Chico Water Heater Buying Guide

Top brands, tank vs. tankless, what it really costs in Chico, and the 5 red flags that cost homeowners thousands. No sales pitch — just the honest read from 30 years on Chico's streets.

DECISION 1

Tank or Tankless?

Every plumber will tell you tankless is "better." It isn't — it's **better for some homes**. Here's the honest read before you spend a dollar.

Tank wins when...

- 1–3 people in the home
- Your gas line & venting are already sized for a tank
- You rarely run multiple hot-water demands at once
- You want the lowest upfront cost

Lifespan: 8–12 years · **Upfront:** \$

Tankless wins when...

- 4+ people / multiple bathrooms running at once
- You've burned through two tanks in 15 years
- You're staying in the home 10+ years (the payback window)
- You want endless hot water & lower energy bills

Lifespan: 18–22 years · **Upfront:** \$\$\$ (gas/venting upgrades usually needed)

The honest test:

If your current setup serves your household and you're not planning to grow, a quality tank install will serve you for the next decade. Don't let anyone upsell you to tankless to pad the invoice — and don't let anyone scare you off it if the math actually works for your home.

THE BRANDS

Top Tank Water Heater Brands

Not all water heaters are built the same. These are the tank brands that earn their place in Chico homes — with the honest trade-offs.

Bradford White — The contractor's choice

Made in the USA and sold through plumbers (not big-box stores), Bradford White is the brand most pros put in their own homes. Built to last with strong tank construction.

+ **Excellent reliability, pro-grade build** – **Not sold at retail; install through a plumber**

A.O. Smith — The big name

One of the largest manufacturers in the world; powers many other labels. Solid, widely available, good range from budget to premium.

+ **Wide availability, good warranties** – **Quality varies by model tier**

Rheem / Ruud — The value pick

Common, affordable, and widely stocked (including at home-improvement stores). A dependable mid-range choice when budget matters.

+ **Affordable, easy to source parts** – **Retail units can be lower-spec than pro lines**

State / American — The quiet workhorses

A.O. Smith-family brands with a strong record in residential installs. Reliable, no-drama options often priced competitively.

+ **Solid value & reliability** – **Less brand-name recognition**

THE BRANDS

Top Tankless Brands

If your home is right for tankless, the brand and the install both matter. These are the names that have proven themselves.

Rinnai — The tankless leader

The best-known tankless brand in North America for good reason: reliable, well-supported, and a wide model range. A safe, proven choice for most Chico homes.

+ **Reliability & parts support** – **Premium pricing on top models**

Navien — The efficiency king

High-efficiency condensing units, often with built-in recirculation for faster hot water at the tap. Great for larger or higher-demand homes.

+ **Top efficiency, recirculation options** – **Needs proper venting & condensate handling**

Noritz — The tankless specialist

A tankless-only manufacturer with a strong commercial and residential track record. Well-built units backed by solid warranties.

+ **Tankless focus, durable** – **Fewer local stocking points**

Bosch — The compact option

Known for compact, efficient units — including point-of-use and electric models for smaller homes or specific applications.

+ **Compact, efficient** – **Best for the right application, not every home**

BEFORE YOU BUY

Sizing, Cost & What to Avoid

How to size it right

Tank: a household of 1–2 usually fits a 40-gallon; 3–4 people a 50-gallon; 5+ a 65–80-gallon or tankless.

Tankless is sized by flow rate (GPM) and how many fixtures run at once — and by Chico's incoming water temperature, which affects output. Get it sized by a pro, not a box-store chart.

What it typically costs

In the Chico area, a standard tank install commonly runs in the low-to-mid four figures; tankless runs higher because it often needs gas-line and venting upgrades. Always get a written quote on *your* home before you commit — the right number depends on your setup, not an ad price.

5 red flags that cost homeowners thousands

- **"It's dead, you need a replacement"** — before any diagnosis. Most "dead" heaters have a bad thermocouple, pilot, or valve.
- **A price quoted before anyone looks at it.** An honest quote comes after the diagnosis, in writing.
- **Pressure to decide today.** A real pro lets you think. Scarcity is a sales tactic.
- **No license number on the quote.** In California, ask for the CSLB number every time.
- **A cheap unit + a rushed install.** The install matters more than the brand — a great heater installed poorly fails early.

The install matters more than the brand.

The best water heater in the world fails early if it's vented wrong, sized wrong, or rushed. After 30 years in Chico, that's the one thing we'd put above any brand name: **who installs it.**

READY FOR AN HONEST QUOTE?

(530) 343-7770

Watkins Plumbing · 30 years in Chico · No upsell. Period. · We diagnose first, replace only when we have to.